

prenup, and neither of us had any interest in wasting a lot of money on a big wedding. The piece of paper was more important to us than the size of the cake and the photo op.

How did we do it? We kept things simple. My best friend was my groomsman and Linda's maid of honor was her best friend. We had the reception in our home, a humble three-bedroom rowhouse with a small backyard. Linda and her friends decorated the place with balloons and fresh-cut flowers. Invitations were written on a DOS program and printed out at home. My wife made her own dress, and her grandparents drove her to the ceremony. I presented her with a simple gold band that cost \$80—which, by the way, she still proudly wears today. We kept the guest list small. Friends who didn't make it onto the list offered to bartend so they could join the party. That was their gift to us, and their way of contributing to keeping the cost of the wedding low. We bought the alcohol at the liquor store. We didn't quite calculate properly and ran out of food, but it was nothing a phone call to a pizza place at midnight couldn't fix. Our one splurge was a night at a hotel before flying out on our honeymoon. That turned out to be our only waste of money. (The fire alarm went off just as we fell asleep. When it happened again an hour later, I ripped the alarm out of the ceiling.)

Perhaps you're thinking our wedding sounds like it was nothing special. You're wrong about that. The focus was exactly where we wanted it to be: on us, our close friends and family, and our commitment to each other. It was a perfect wedding for many reasons, but mostly because we didn't drain our savings and enter marriage in debt. Remember this if you're planning a wedding: Memories are created by people, not products.